grandfather, the Padshah, and ‘little by little as his years progressed real potential was noticed in him. He served my exalted father more and better than any of my sons and my father was very pleased with him and his service. He always commended him to me. Many times he said “There is no comparison between him and your other sons. I consider him my true son”.’ Salim may have found it galling that Akbar considered Khurram his true son, given the increasing disappointment the Padshah expressed in his own sons.

Khurram would remain in Ruqaiya Begum’s care until Akbar died and Salim became Padshah Jahangir, when Khurram was thirteen years old. So while Akbar may have been honouring Ruqaiya Begum by giving her what she had requested, he was also demonstrating, yet again, the faith he had in the senior Timurid matriarchs. Hamida Banu, Salima Sultan, Gulbadan, and Ruqaiya were the ones who were often trusted with the care and education of the Mughal children. And if many of them were now born of Rajput mothers, their upbringing was strictly Timurid. It was these women who surrounded them with the language, the etiquette, the food and the nuances of culture that they were the guardians of.

All the major celebrations at court, the births and the marriages, were also supervised by these senior women and it was Hamida Banu, helped by the other matriarchs, who decided on the giving of gifts, the dances, the decorations, and all the festivities as they became ever more elaborate. The women had many occasions to admire and acquire new luxuries and innovations, for Akbar, intensely curious about every new development, created occasions for the women of the harem to enjoy these too:

> On the third feast-day of every month, His Majesty holds a large assembly for the purpose of inquiring into the many wonderful things found in this world. The merchants of the age are eager to attend, and lay out articles from all countries. The people of His Majesty’s Harem come, and the women of other men are also invited, and buying and selling is quite general. His Majesty uses such days to select any articles which he wishes to buy or to fix the prices of things, and thus add to his knowledge. His Majesty gives to such days the name of Khushruz, or the joyful day, as they are a source of much enjoyment.

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